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James Hunter

James Hunter was born on October 2, 1962 in Colchester, England. His distinctive voice and guitar skills and knack for composing memorable R&B songs have made the James Hunter Six a popular act in Great Britain and the U.S. His 2006 release "People Gonna Talk" was nominated for a Grammy Award in the Traditional Blues category.

James was interviewed by Monk Rowe before a gig at the City Winery in Boston, MA on July 25, 2018. Romy Britell also participated in the interview.

[Pre-interview]

JH: If you all will face this way, my hair is a bit best that side.

MR: Which is your best side?

JH: I'm sitting on mine. These are our jokes folks, we've got more.

RB: The camera is rolling, be careful.

JH: Is it? Ah, nothing incriminating.

MR: Yeah, but the "tape."

JH: "I had nothing to do with the Balmouth killings, I was in Brighton at the time. So I'd like to clear that up.

MR: We'll have to get some witnesses on that though.

JH: Yes.

MR: Yes.

JH: Jess? All right, looks like I did it.

MR: So my name is Monk Rowe and I am with the Fillius Jazz Archive and we are in Boston at the City Winery and I'm very pleased to have James Hunter here with me. So how did you find America?

JH: No, I'm not going to do that one.

MR: We don't want to go there.

JH: Well you mean this time or the first time?

MR: The first time.

JH: The first time, very large. There's a lot more of it than I thought. And I didn't realize how much of it, talking our geography here, I didn't realize how much of it was the south. I didn't realize it started so soon, you know, just under Washington.

MR: Correct. That's about mid-way.

JH: And I thought it was the bottom quarter. There's about three-quarters of it, isn't it?

MR: Do you find audiences here any different than in Great Britain?

JH: Not markedly in terms of, what do you call it, in terms of reaction you know. We get the same reaction. I'm not going to say whether it's good or bad but it's the same.

MR: It's the same. You've got to follow up on that.

JH: People who like it like it a lot you know. Some of the places they can tend to be a bit more elderly you know. It depends where you go. It depends, in the cities it tends to be a younger lot and then the further out in the sticks you go they tend to be more elderly. I'm talking about people my age.

MR: I'm going to pose a very deep musical question to you.

JH: Ah quite, well I'm unqualified for that one but I'll have a stab.

MR: Do you remember the first time you heard the groove [scats]?

JH: Oh the one I'm always using. Yeah I mean I'd always heard variations of it. I mean the first kind of really popular one would have been "There Goes My Baby" by the Drifters I suppose. And that's why, it's because of that record that almost everything from 1959 onwards had a variation of that sort of beat. And for some reason it fell out of favor by the mid-60s, to be replaced by [scats] which is equally good but somehow not as infectious, not always.

MR: And it's danceable too.

JH: It is. I've always dug it. And it mystified me how that kind of fell out of popular use. And I've overused it myself as a kind of compensatory thing.

MR: I was looking at the top pop songs in Great Britain about the time you were 13 or 14.

JH: Right, which would have been 1975, about then.

MR: And it's a very mixed bag. You've just got some sort of very corny tunes on there, you've got the start of some heavier rock & roll, and can I ask you why you didn't go the sort of Led Zeppelin route?

JH: I mean much as I like that stuff and approve of it, those sort of guitar sounds kind of like there's a level of distortion where it becomes a bit mushy for me and it loses a bit of bite. So I like it so you can still hear what's going on. It's like having a curry that's too hot that you can't taste it. So I do like definition with my filth. You know? Which is why I kind of like that period where people were just starting to overdrive them a bit.

MR: I think I read that you know what those black flat things are that go round at 78 rpm are.

JH: Oh is that what they are, where the thing jumps.

MR: Yeah.

JH: That's right.

MR: You got turned on to music through 78s?

JH: Well yeah, kind of initially. It gave me a taste for a sort of more finished start I suppose. For some reason it gave me a taste for stuff of a certain age. Of course a lot of that stuff is only about say twelve years old at the time that I was listening to it. It seemed old enough

to be another world really, and it was when I was, we were living in this little caravan in Thorrington Cross which is just outside Colchester, where it's quite remote really. And there wasn't much entertainment. We had a bit of a housing situation and no television, which was probably a plus. It would be more of a plus these days to be honest. But yeah, on weekends, because of the limited amount of room in this caravan, it was a family of four we were living there, and weekends we'd be allowed to drag out the, fold my mom and dad's bed up into the wall and drag the record player out.

MR: Were you a dancer?

JH: Never.

MR: You never danced to that.

JH: Not until last New Year's Eve, as my wife dragged me out on the dance floor when we went out New Year's Eve and that's the first time I voluntarily did it. In fact I think it was my idea.

MR: Was it a slow one or a fast one?

JH: Fast. It was a Gene Vincent tune. It was a more obscure one of his. Slightly souly sounding. I wish I could remember what it was. But yeah, I just dragged her on the floor. And all that time I've been a professional wallflower, right up until then.

MR: When did the guitar come into your hands?

JH: Fourteen years old, 1976. My brother got fed up. He bought one the year before and he got fed up with my messing his scratch plate up. He's one of those people who cares what his guitar looks like. He's a very good guitarist himself and to sort of keep me off his guitar he prevailed on his best pal to sell me his guitar, which was like basically almost just one step up from a cigar box with a cheese cutter sort of strings on it.

MR: Was it electric?

JH: No it was acoustic. Two quid that cost me. I don't think it even had a brand name you know.

MR: When you first started learning chords, I'm not sure how to put this, but did you know what they were?

JH: Yeah. You mean the names of them?

MR: Yes, the names of them.

JH: Yeah Perry, my brother, taught me the first. And the one that really looks as if it's going to be difficult is an open G and you see someone do it and you think how do you distort your finger? And that's really easy but it looks difficult. So but the ones that actually drove me to tears were the bar chords. But once I got hold of them, as my wife will tell you I cheat with the A shaped bar chords. You're supposed to have these three fingers together and then that bar across. See I can't do that so I just use the little finger and turn

it into a sixth. And if I don't want it to be a sixth I don't hit the thinnest string. That's how I get round it.

MR: It's funny you mentioned the sixth because one of my favorite songs of yours, which we'll get to, has sixes all over it.

JH: Is that right. Oh the chords you mean? A lot of them do I think, yeah. But all right, we'll get to it.

MR: Musicians, in my own experience, always are trying to get to the next level. They're trying to "make it."

JH: Yeah.

MR: And what level did you start at?

JH: Well below the poverty line. So you know, yeah I mean I started as a struggling — well I think maybe every ten or it might be every twenty years something happens that lifts the profile up and, you know, brings people in. We have a sort of something that looks like a big break. So it happened when I first left, around the first time I left Colchester to go to London. We were basically a busking outfit, the band I had, and we used to busk on the corner of Camden Lock and we had got quite a following and we actually got invited to do indoor gigs. So the street followed us indoors. And we nearly got caught up in a bidding war, which both sides voluntarily lost.

MR: You mean from a record company?

JH: Yeah, two record companies fighting over us. I think the conversation might have gone, "You have him." "No, you have him." You know. But you know that didn't really sort of end up happening but we got on this TV program called "The Tube" on channel 4. And there was a huge interest in us after that. The very next pub date we played was absolutely packed to the rafters and that was one of those big steps up.

MR: You're talking about "we." How many were in "we."

JH: Oh there was four of us at the time. I used to double or alternate between harmonica and guitar. We had a female guitarist, her name was Dot and was brilliant. And double bass and drums. So it was, people used to think we were sort of a rockabilly outfit you know, just cause of the double bass. I think a lot of people, at that time, in the 80s, they would have probably thought Charles Mingus was rockabilly. They weren't used to seeing a double bass outside the context of the philharmonic orchestra.

MR: That's right. But if you think about it, the early Elvis and all that stuff —

JH: Was all influenced by blacks, R&B, yeah totally.

MR: Were you doing your own tunes at that early point?

JH: A handful of them. I mean we were like a covers band doing what we thought were obscure covers. We were trying not to be complete copyists. We'd do the lesser well known things that were standard. I can't remember what we would have done now.

Actually I think I did things that I thought nobody had covered like "Further On Up the Road" by Bobby Bland. I didn't realize that your Claptons and whatnot had already done it to death since then, which I thought that was an indication I was a good judge of a song, because I mean I found several, a long time ago sort of there was an Ivory Joe Hunter tune called "I Need You So" and I started doing that occasionally if we were busking. And I saw it on the arse end of a compilation of his stuff, thinking it was just some obscure, and I didn't realize it had become an R&B standard, that every vocal group used to do it. I had no idea. So I thought that I'm not a bad judge then, am I?

MR: Did you feel compelled to try to re-create what you heard on these records as close as possible?

JH: Less re-create than, what do you call it, there is a word for it, emulate.

MR: Emulate.

JH: Yeah, trying to get the same spirit of that and I think you can stultify something by trying to absolutely replicate it so I was trying to, I was trying to convey the same spirit. I always felt that for the most part, with a few exceptions that white America and British acts who attempted that style of music used to lose the finesse and they'd compensate by adding a bit more aggression. But the slinkiness, the sort of sinuous poetics of grace of the way the black performers used to do it I think was lost on a lot of us Caucasians. So I tried to copy that element of it. I mean sometimes people like Georgie Fame would get the groove, they'd find the groove, I mean, and Duffy Power, he was another more obscure sort of British white soul singer, and he'd add his own little thing of strangeness to it. He used to transcend that thing of copyist. He'd add his own element to it.

MR: Were you compelled by, or suggested to by producers, like, "James if you just would do this we could sign you" or —

JH: No. I never had that carrot dangled in front of me. I was lucky. I don't know how resolute I would have been if I'd been faced by any sort of temptation or whatever. There was maybe a couple of instances but the promise wasn't, you know, maybe the carrot wasn't big enough for me to go for it.

MR: To get up to that next level or whatever.

JH: Yeah It didn't seem like it was going to be an obvious next step. But I don't really remember being tempted you know.

MR: So you spent a lot of time playing pubs and ten to two type gigs or was it longer than that?

JH: Oh sometimes it was that and there was a little bar we used to do near Carnaby Street, it had a pretty grueling night shift you know. It was not quite the same as the Beatles would have been doing in Hamburg but it was enough. But most of the pubs were kind of like

regular hours, from nine until about — I don't know, the doors would open at nine and it'd be finished by midnight. So that was fairly lenient. Nothing too grueling.

MR: Yeah I was wondering if there were times in your life where you worked like a day job and played at night too.

JH: No. Not since I left — when I worked on the railway before I left to come to London I was a railway worker during the day and on the weekends I'd sneak off to London and do the music. And I left that. And it wasn't until fifteen years later, yeah, about fifteen years later I started working — when the gigs started to thin out I started to do casual labor through an agency. And of course it was pretty good because if a little tour came up I could say I'm not available that week. So apart from the fact that the agency would stitch you up at every opportunity, you still had the freedom to pick and choose where you wanted to work.

MR: So you got acknowledgement from *MoJo Magazine*: "U.K.'s Greatest Soul Singer."

JH: Oh. Well I don't know if it's true but I don't mind people saying that.

MR: Well I'd like to say that by the power vested in me, I'm going to call you "King of the Hooks."

JH: Oh great.

MR: Because I just think, not just me, my whole family, we were turned on to your music by our daughter by the way.

JH: Oh yeah?

MR: Who, she's thirty —

RB: Six.

JH: Oh right.

MR: And she sent us, you've got to watch this guy. And I find your music to be immediately grabbing and I wonder how that happened?

JH: Well I do sort of maybe unconsciously study how a pop song works, you know. Because the stuff I'm doing is, to all intents and purposes, soul and R&B is pop music, altogether geared towards a particular market. It's all meant to be commercial music and for people to engage with it it does need to be quite conversational and flow and have something identifiable in it. So yeah I do that sort of consciously.

MR: And you don't wait too long to get to the point.

JH: Yeah I think so. I mean I do like short records. I mean people like Bob Dylan started doing really long ones because, and they used to have to keep it short apparently so that the juke boxes wouldn't, the album wouldn't lift up too soon. I think that's why they were all, up to the early 60s they were all two and a half minutes. But Bob Dylan sort of pretty much broke that with "Like a Rolling Stone" simply because he had a lot to say that couldn't be contained in that amount of time. And I think by the 80s though, the only

reason records, singles were in excess of four minutes long was because the bulk of the track was the fade out.

MR: That's true.

JH: It's all fade out and the chorus just goes round and round and outstays its welcome. And I think that's what happened.

MR: Yeah like producers were really slow pulling that thing down.

JH: I think people were starting to look in terms of sheer volume rather than, you know, what was actually being said.

MR: So the James Hunter Six has this, in my opinion, has this identifiable sound. And I think part of it is because you're still playing with a stand up bass.

JH: Yeah I think probably. It has a certain warmth to it you know, and it was a shame it disappeared entirely for a while in popular music.

MR: Yeah. And it doesn't dominate the music like an electric bass can.

JH: No that's right. You know like basically a rhythm section in a record appeals to me it sort of just sits in the pocket and drives it along and sometimes you're not that conscious of it being there, you just feel it. It's very much the case, a good example is somebody like Bill Doggett, whose contributions to his own records aren't always readily sort of apparent but he's there driving it from underneath with the bass pedals making it sort of throb along. And you can't hear what he's doing but you can feel it.

MR: Exactly. You go to put that, you go okay what key is he in and you put your ear closer to the speaker to pick out those bass notes.

JH: It's nice if you have to look for it, yeah.

MR: Yeah. It's nice if you have to look for it, I like that. I also wondered, how did you settle, or maybe it wasn't settling, but with two tenors, or the tenor and the baritone, rather than, if you had an alto and a trumpet your band would sound a lot different.

JH: It would be different. I mean the thing is, the reason I initially went for that is cause you could get the most range, or the most variety of sounds between the two. So I went for that initially because a lot of the New Orleans rhythm & blues stuff I was listening to like Guitar Slim, Edgar Blanchard, was using this doubled up tenor and baritone playing octaves apart so which give it a sort of fat spectrum of sound. But my idea was to not always just keep it to that, but to get as much variety as I could. And so a typical (what do you call it) arrangement of mine will have them maybe start doing an octave and then swoop in and meet each other and do a harmony, and then come back out again. And so it was the idea of making very little sound like a lot you know. You simply weren't sure how much, sometimes I'll throw — the guitar will join in and make a third part. Or I'll have them back up a vocal phrase. I'll have a three-part harmony. They'll be covering a vocal phrase with.

MR: Oh you've got one melody that you're singing and the saxes are —

JH: That's right. They're harmonizing with me. So it's like the instrument that'll do it. I don't know how often that's been done but you know I thought of doing that. Just to fill out the sound. Because I used to see a lot of soul or R&B bands used to have an enormous horn section, you'd have everything, but they'd all be playing the same part. And I think it's easier to pick out when you've got a few. And I mean I'd say I'd make better use of a lot of horns if I had them. But I always felt it's a waste of a horn section. You've got them all doing the same thing throughout. Say if it's a baritone he's just popping and he just blasts the low notes.

MR: [Scats]

JH: Yeah. Oh and idea I got from that minimalist thing of getting a little bit to sound like a lot was a bass player we worked with years ago with an old incarnation of this band, Dave Lanyardo. He lent me this album and it was late 30s sort of Duke Ellington, small group stuff. I was never into that big band game really, but this was Duke Ellington with Rex Stewart and Johnny Hodges was it.

MR: On alto, yeah.

JH: Yeah. And it's a small three horn — what do you call it — section with just a basic rhythm section underneath, bass, drums, piano. And the amount of stuff they'd get up to with that, you know. Two of them would keep this little harmonized vamp going on, and one would be out front soloing, and then when he steps back in and they change it when another one steps out to solo. And they modify the thing to suit what the remaining two instruments are playing. And I thought that's a way, it sounds like a big wall of sound but there's only three horns playing. And I think I nicked the idea from that.

MR: That's great. You have to know what notes to pick I think.

JH: Yeah.

MR: For the horn players. And so do your horn players make up those parts or do you?

JH: I do that, yeah. They contribute to it. They'll add suggestions. But for the most part, it's fairly easy for me 'cause I couldn't just spin most of it out of my own head and just hum it to them and play it, I'm able to pick it out on the guitar, what will harmonize. So if you play an instrument that you can hit more than one note simultaneously, like a piano or a guitar, it's fairly easy to pick out harmonies. So I give — generally the tenor gets the melodic line that the people remember. But the baritone players gets the thankless task of playing something really unmelodic to harmonize with it so it will stick like a coat of paint. With what I usually give to the baritone player you couldn't whistle it to him you know. You couldn't say do that. Because you can't remember it. You just have to re-pick it out and it goes with the top line. So it's quite challenging.

MR: When you say that because a lot of times in big band music the lower parts, which sometimes were assigned to the less skillful players, were actually the harder parts.

JH: They are, because you can't remember them. They don't stick in your mind.

MR: They're not melodic and sometimes the fingerings are weird because those are the notes that are needed and all that.

JH: That's right, they don't suit that instrument or whatever, and they're not comfortable in the key that that horn is usually set to. And I sometimes do, I sometimes, just arbitrarily written stuff in keys that aren't traditional guitar keys as well, either to make things easier for the horn players, or to see if my voice sounds any different. So I've written one in A flat, I just did it for the sake of it, just so I could tell people that's an A flat. It's purely that. To show it off.

MR: You get points for that.

JH: Oh yeah. And B, B's not very common for guitarists, and —

MR: And that puts the horns in, well the alto it puts him in A flat anyway, or D flat.

JH: Yeah and they like that, they like your B flats and something. But A flat I think was a good one for them, I can't remember. Well I did once pick a key that was really uncomfortable for all of us in my opinion, I can't remember.

MR: Well you're obviously comfortable with that but I wonder if early on did you have this moment where you were playing horn parts on the guitar and you were telling the sax players, "It's an A." And they're going, "No it's not."

JH: Oh yeah, they taught me one straight on, and it's purely that their A is different from my A just so that the writing will make sense. Somebody explained to me why and I got it. But I understand why but I can't explain it.

MR: Are your charts written down?

JH: Usually by the horn players. Not me. I did try and teach myself to write music so I could just sketch it out and give it to them. But I got two bars in and gave up. But apparently I was reliably informed I had got it right. But I just bought this rudimentary guide called Learn Yourself Music Right. Something like that. And I did manage to do two whole bars of this passage. But I might get my finger out and teach myself again you know.

MR: So when we watch the group tonight, will we see any music stands on the stage?

JH: No. These folks have an incredible sort of memorizing stuff. I don't think I'd be capable of that level of discipline but they — I've got a cheat sheet because I've written a new song that I haven't recorded yet and I'll bring that down. It takes me ages to memorize. I used to think I was a quick study but I'm not really. My songs are very verbose you know. So it's a bit of a memorize job but these guys have got everything down pat.

MR: You've written so many tunes I'm wondering if you have trouble remembering your own songs.

JH: Only when somebody mentions it, because our drummer once said, "You know what? You're the only singer I've worked with who never forgets his lyrics." And that night I forgot two of them.

MR: Okay. I don't mean to jinx you.

JH: It's got me thinking about it, you forget you know. It relies on — this is the reason I'm usually quite careful to like, this sounds really bigheaded, which I am, but I try and write a really coherent narrative structure in my songs so that if I do forget what the next verse is going to be I think about what I've just sung and think well if this was me talking what would I say next? And usually that leads me to what the second verse was. So it's a great help in memorizing songs if you're not a quick study.

MR: Okay name this James Hunter tune: It's a piano lick [scats] it heads into the bridge of the song. It's one of my favorite moments.

JH: Which one is that?

MR: And it's got those sixth chords in it.

JH: Well hell. You sang it very nicely but I don't recognize it without the rest of the track.

MR: That's right. It was "I'll Walk Away."

JH: Oh right. What did we have on that? That was the piano player doing that. Ah yes. He threw that in. That wasn't my contribution. I just went into a seventh.

MR: Okay.

JH: And I said, "Do something around that." That was a fella called Tom playing piano on that.

MR: Well when you're talking about sixth chords —

JH: And he took the secret with him when he left the studio.

MR: I'm fascinated by, with that particular song let's say because you've got [scats] on a sixth chord and the bass is going [scats]. And just that. Just that, is a hook.

JH: I guess it is. It's what you could call a riff couldn't you, and it sticks in people's minds. I always did like sixth chords because first, they're also ambiguous. You can replace them with a minor and they're sort of interchangeable and they sound pretty.

MR: Yeah. And you can sort of sing bluesy over them too, choose which way to go.

JH: You can. I mean one tenor player we had I used to write a convoluted sort of chord sequence for him to solo over, and he'd play in order to show, sometimes he'd play in order to show he understood where the chords were going. And sometimes it would be unnecessary. And I said, "No just play blues over that," I said, "the tune is in the chords. You just flop over it and do it, it doesn't matter, but the tune's all in the chords." But I think he wanted to show me he was paying attention.

MR: That is true, horn players like to, "I know what you're doing here."

JH: Yeah I'm like it myself, I like to show I know what's going on, whether I do or not.

MR: Lyrically, where do your ideas come from?

JH: Well real life, either mine or other people's. You know, or imagined conversations, what I would have said to somebody you know under certain circumstances which haven't actually happened. So yeah it's just all observations, some things like that. You know anything that's all my own half-baked opinions you know, just rhyme them up and set them to music.

MR: Here's one I really like, "If lying and cheating was any kind of crime/A hundred years from now you'd still be doing time."

JH: Yeah I was quite pleased with that one. It's probably a variation on stuff that's been said before. My favorite rhyme is in "This is Where We Came In" "Here comes the part where they start falling for one another/I know it by heart like déjà something or other. It's hard to sing that one.

MR: I believe I read that your stories are mostly fiction but the names are true?

JH: Well that's right, real names and fictitious stories. Did I actually say that at one point?

MR: Someone said that you said it.

JH: I did say something correctly there. They're pretend stories but the real names have been used to implicate the innocent.

MR: Maybe it's my imagination but your album, I think it was from '08, had more players on it. Had some strings.

JH: Oh yeah.

MR: And a vibes player.

JH: That's right.

MR: And then —

JH: Usually the vibes and percussion were doing by the same person so it was one person doing multiple roles but we did get a string section in on that's "The Hard Way" album for a couple.

RB: And "People Gonna Talk."

JH: And "People Gonna Talk." That too. With both of those albums. But we did bring a string section in for one track on "Minute by Minute" as well for "Let the Monkey Ride." Very minimal but we sort of put that in.

MR: Does some of that depend on your budget?

JH: Yeah, yeah it does, yeah. And sometimes something will fit. There have been times where we've just thrown something in, you know, if we could get it. We just did it because we could, not because we should. You know, we can dress this one up and it will sound different from what's going on. Which one should we put it on? It was a matter of that occasionally but yeah, sometimes it's nice to dress a thing up just for the sake of it.

MR: And again are you sort of suggesting to these players what to do?

JH: Well our tenor player at the time would write out, I think he had a good grasp of what my sort of tastes were and he'd — the strings was usually his contribution. He would write that there.

MR: You've got some licks that you like. [scats]

JH: Which one is that? That's the one that's in all of them.

MR: Well I think that was "You Can't Win."

JH: Oh "You Can't Win" here we're going back here aren't we. Yeah. Yeah that was just tacked on. That wasn't like really integral. That was just to give the horn players something to do. We're all here, we might as well do something. You know. That's why that one didn't really stick in my mind that much. What I did was I wrote that song around about 2001 and then I wrote the third verse several months later, I think by the next year, the one about holding the target still. And I sort of questioned myself, is that too silly to put in or is that too comical? And I thought no, keep it in. And I've done that several times since. I've gone is that line too funny, is it against the grain of the song? And I think well anything that distinguishes it from, you know, that marks you out as being different has got to be good.

MR: Definitely. Good turn of a phrase.

JH: Yeah.

RB: But can I ask why that song isn't called "I Can't Win?"

JH: Because "You Can't Win" — that's a good question, but it's a more recognizable phrase. People use it more often, you can't win, in the sense of one can't win you know.

RB: But it's not in the song, right?

JH: It's not in the song. Right. So I will generally, for a title I'll chose a more recognizable phrase over a literal one. Because the whole point is making use of a well-worn familiar phrase. So you can't win is something you'll hear people more often, they'll be referring to themselves anyway, so. Yeah, that's why.

MR: If you get a phrase like that in your head do you — oh that could be a song?

JH: Yeah.

MR: Do you get the guitar and just start —

JH: Sometimes yeah I'll do that, and I'll try and find things to do with it. A prime example is "This is Where We Came in" it's a phrase that you don't hear these days because cinemas don't let people stay there for a second house do they. They chuck everybody out. And nowadays — you'd walk in halfway through a film and you'd sit it through to the end and wait for the adverts to come round and then catch up until the moment where, and that's what, that's that phrase people used to use. And I always thought that phrase was crying out to have a song made of it, like an analogy for a relationship that's going tits up you know. You know, you can see where this is going you know. So that's one I used.

And yeah, usually that's the thing about pop music, it's sort of a familiarity — if you sometimes write something that you're surprised somebody hasn't written already you know, that's the kind of thing that somebody should have written by now. Why hasn't somebody written a song called that. And that's where I'm going. I think I'm starting from 1960 and sort of trying to point where, but for an accident of providence where popular music might have gone you know. But I'm developing it very slowly.

MR: You've got a lot of ground to cover.

JH: Yeah, really, yeah.

MR: I suppose nowadays you could YouTube something and see if someone actually did write a song that — you're thinking about a phrase and you mind find that —

JH: Oh I've done that, I've done that with "Minute by Minute." I saw that on a —

MR: Doobie Brothers.

JH: Yeah I didn't know, I found out afterwards. I saw it on a picture of a film poster for a film called "Ring of Fire" with Dwayne Eddy doing the soundtrack and Frank Gorshin as the villain. It's about a cop taking a hostage through a burning forest and the blurb on the thing says "Minute by minute" the something and it just stuck in my head and I went oh I'm having that. That just sounded good. And I checked, before I wrote it I checked to see if anyone had written one called that and Doobie Brothers had and I thought well sod it, I'm doing it anyway. Because you can't copyright a phrase like that. I think a lot of my titles are fairly, you know, most of them would have been used in one shape or another before, except things like "Let the Monkey Ride." That's nobody's.

RB: I googled that phrase. I said to myself what does that mean.

JH: Nobody's even said it.

RB: It all came back to you. That's all it was.

JH: That's right.

RB: So I had to read the lyrics to figure it out for myself.

JH: Yeah. That's it. And it's really, it was all used in the context of the well known phrase having a monkey on your back. That one I was going the opposite route of the Stones, you know, with "Brown Sugar." You know they're writing about you're supposed to think they're writing about a bird, you know, a girlfriend, and they're actually writing about heroin. And I'm doing the opposite. I'm writing about the girl but trying to make it sound like it's Persian rugs you know.

MR: You're a back door man.

JH: Yeah, yeah. That's an ambiguous phrase as well.

MR: Yes indeed. When you write your set list for tonight what goes into that?

JH: Same stuff we've been doing the whole tour. Yeah, we've got it printed out. Yeah I don't tailor it around, you know, we stick to one and just get used to the shape of it Yeah.

Sometimes I mean we've got enough stuff, you know, but I don't move it around very often you know. I might change it for the next tour.

MR: And you're on Daptone now?

JH: Yeah.

MR: And you recorded — sometimes you record straight to eight track?

JH: Yeah.

MR: What a unique idea.

JH: Well they always do that. Well not really it's been done to death in the old days hasn't it.

MR: Yes.

JH: It's just that very few people are doing it now.

MR: Yeah. People tend to get — when they have all this gear they can use you feel like you want to use it.

JH: Yeah. Well in Gabe's case, Gabe Roth, he says you can do anything on digital that you can do on analog, he just prefers the process. He just enjoys it more, you know, the editing and everything. He says you can get all the effects and sounds. His whole thing is mic placement, you know, where you put the mic and what mic to use. That's how you get the sound.

MR: A British journalist I met reminded me of the phrase "across the pond."

JH: Oh yeah, yeah.

MR: Which we probably both use to each other's countries.

JH: Yeah.

MR: And we take a certain amount of interest in things across the pond like Brexit and so forth. And I wonder if it's the same for you and your band mates. Do they observe what's happening in the United States?

JH: Certainly yeah. I mean with what's going on here now, I mean there's nobody that's not aware of it. I mean you know American politics is usually at the forefront, and I suppose — of the British news, we're all very aware of that, and maybe to a lesser extent the — America knows what's going on with Britain. But it's a sheer matter of scale really, because there's a lot of America so there's going to be a lot of people who aren't aware of the Brexit thing. But very few people in England wouldn't be aware of, you know, the current incumbent — how do I start to describe it — but yeah. Yeah everybody knows what's going on, yeah.

MR: Does it seem inexplicable?

JH: Yeah. I suppose it's starting to become explicable. You know it sounds fanciful but you know it's hard to believe he got voted in, isn't it?

MR: Indeed.

JH: Yeah I mean but we've got — our leader at home is this vacuous follower who basically will do anything to latch on to power including falling in with, you know, sort of extreme right wing parties like the DUP you know. That's how she got her false majority to stay in power after a hung Parliament. I mean she called a what do you call it, she called a general election thinking she was going to get a huge mandate and she made a cut of it. Yeah, ah well, I'm a Corbyn man you know. I want him in. Because people say all the other stuff about him and a lot of it — I mean we're dominated by a right wing press at home. Most of it is owned by one Australian. And anyone who doesn't want the National Health Service to be sold off to various bids is regarded as a hard line Marxist. It's ridiculous. The National Health Service was founded after the last war and it was state-run healthcare for anybody, whether they can afford it or not. And the — our government sees that as an asset to be demolished and sold off. They've always seen it like that. Ever since 1945 they've been trying to destroy it.

MR: Well some things are sort of the same across the pond. Who are your musical heroes?

JH: Well when I was a teenager it was I think Eddie Cochran and Gene Vincent I got into. From them into Ray Charles, or that might have been simultaneous. And then I went more sort of underground and discovered the Five Royales and that was, I remember when we worked with Allen Toussaint he was quite what do you call it, impressed that I'd even heard of them because he said that back in the day it was only really ultra-hip black people had heard of the Five Royales. They were a regional phenomenon. They weren't a world-wide, a nation-wide success, they were a regional act. And a bit of an underground secret, even in their prime.

MR: Were you a guy, when you were young went to the record stores.

JH: Yeah. Browsed through for pretty obscure stuff and that. I remember reading about Clyde McPhatter and deciding, just on the description, that he was my favorite singer. I'd never heard him. But the way this bloke described his voice I thought I've got to hear this. And this is about 1980s. You couldn't find it. They weren't re-issuing that sort of stuff. And so I went in this little record shop in Southend-on-Sea on my lunch break, because that was Southend-on-Sea in Essex was within our jurisdiction as a signal box maintenance man. So on my lunch break I went off to this little place and they had a box full of, they were reissued singles that you couldn't find most places. So I got firsthand proof of how good he was.

MR: You know the thing you mentioned, liner notes, were great back then.

JH: Yeah. You had something to read.

MR: Yes you had something to read and, as you said, it might catch your ear through reading it. What do you envision five years from now for yourself and your band?

JH: No idea. I just — I take it day by day. I've never had a five year plan. I never give a satisfactory answer to that question because I haven't got a clue. What happens happens. And I just try and — I think like you mentioned earlier, try and outdo myself each time, try to make a better record. But I don't know how different it needs to be. My real ambition is to make the sort of record that I would rush out and buy if I heard it. That's purely it. And get paid for it you know. Make more money. That's about it really.

MR: Have you toured the continent?

JH: Yeah, quite a lot.

MR: Are you anxious to get home?

JH: Yeah I wouldn't mind, but we haven't been out here that long. Yeah I wouldn't mind getting back. Yeah we've got a lot of laundry to do haven't we? That's it. It's just flying by isn't it?

MR: Do you have to do anything to try to keep your voice healthy?

JH: I drink loads of water. Apart from that nothing, no. I used to warm up, but only when my voice was already suffering. It's like shutting the stable door after the horse has bolted really, but Jessie got me to drink loads of water which helped a lot. And she persuaded me, almost persuaded me to cut down smoking which I'm down to eighty a day now.

MR: Well if I saw you in a year you could say, "I've quit four times already."

JH: Which I know exactly. I did tell of, it takes a lot of willpower to quit that many times.

MR: Any questions I haven't asked you that you'd like to comment.

JH: Na. I can't ask myself questions.

MR: Do you have a —

RB: How come there's no words on the Daptones?

JH: I don't know. I think it's just not their policy. I actually fought it when we first did it. I thought we don't need that. Because I always thought the words aren't that important enough. And then when they insisted, my manager insisted on my early records, I went along with it and thought no, I don't mind showing off the lyrics.

RB: Well as Monk said, but at least you can understand the words. You know?

JH: I thought that was my rationale for not including them because they were fairly apparent you know and I think that a lot of records where they did that was because when the backing track would overpower the vocals anyway so you needed subtitles.

RB: Stevie Winwood or something.

JH: Yeah. But I didn't initially think it was necessary. Now I sort of like it. But I think maybe it's cause at that time the main thing is the, what do you call it, the vinyl. Vinyl is the main product for them and the CDs are a kind of incidental market for them, and you didn't tend to get lyrics in with the LPs whereas you get a booklet with the — you tend to get a booklet with the CD.

RB: The cardboard ones are bad. Although the "Minute by Minute" one has it.

JH: That one did, didn't it, right up until "Hold On" didn't have them. Did "Minute by Minute" have the lyrics in?

RB: Yeah it had a slide in.

JH: Yeah that's right. It did, yeah. I don't know, I'll ask them. I won't to fight tooth and nail because maybe people have more fun figuring them out you know.

MR: Okay. The old fashioned way, you'd sit and write them down.

JH: Yeah that's right.

MR: Have you ever had another band cover your tunes?

JH: Lots of times, yeah.

MR: That's great.

JH: Yeah it's nice to hear. What was her name now, this nice lady who covered "Kick It Around." Lisa Mills. She's American but she does a lot of her work in England. And she covered "Kick It Around." She sang it very well but I can't let her off because she left off these — I said you took out two chords that distinguished it. It was in C something and there was an A flat and I said what did you leave that out for? That's the best bit. She took it very well.

MR: Do you own your own publishing?

JH: No I don't. I think we've got in-house publishing with the record. Somebody did try to persuade me to start a publishing company and I don't know if I could have made more loot with that or not. Maybe it's worth looking into.

MR: Okay so I'll wrap up here. What makes one of your compositions, one of your tunes, not get on a record?

JH: Oh if it's a bit too generic. But for shorter stuff I'll put it in. If it sounds like anyone could have written it, if it really sounds — doesn't have any distinctive touches or, you know, then I'll feel like — because sometimes I've deliberately tried, just for the sake of writing something, to write something generic like anyone would have written, like a stand upon it, and then you can't help putting your own stamp on it. By the third verse — I mean I write to a formula. I tend to do this a bit like sitcoms comedy, two straight lines and a funny one. And I'll do that in verses. I'll do two straight verses and then I'll throw a joke in the third one you know. And it often happens with me. So I'll do that.

MR: You are the only guy I know who rhymed with cul-de-sac.

JH: What song was that? Oh yeah, cul-de-sac/don't come back wasn't it.

MR: I finally made it back/from that lonely cul-de-sac.

JH: Oh no that's "One Way Love." Somebody must've done it. But I'm the only person I know who did it.

MR: Well we're looking forward to the gig tonight.

JH: Well thanks very much.

MR: And I appreciate your time very much, and I hope that we cross paths again.

JH: Certainly.

MR: Thanks a lot.

JH: Take care then.